# *On ultimate 0. Possession and dumping*

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Welcome to (Reynolds) *on ultimate*; a series of two-pagers about strategy and tactics for playing frisbee. There's a lot to think about[1], and explaining stuff on the field or at trainings can be challenging. These notes aim to be a written resource instead, focusing on horizontal and vertical offensive structures (against person-match defence) and offense against 3-3-1 and 2-3-2 zone structures[2].

Each possession might end in: 1) a score[3]; 2) a turnover because of defensive actions[4]; or 3) a turnover through unforced error[5]. Throughout a game of ultimate the difference between the two teams' scores is related to the difference in the number turnovers (Outcomes 2 or 3) that each team has had.

Probability of a turnover (2 or 3) instead of a score (1) is a function of the number of passes made prior to scoring and the pass completion rate. Hence, fewer passes[6] and/or higher completion rates[7] might be preferred. Reality is more complex, with completion rates varying by thrower, receiver, throw and situation[8]. There's a balance[9], but if you receive the pull the 'desired' result is retaining possession until you score[10], or scoring despite losing possession at least once[11], while the 'bad' outcome is they score and you receive another pull next point[12].

Typically defence sets the agenda and offense has to respond: if the defence defends each person individually ('person-match') then throwing into space may be easier; if the defence covers space instead ('zone', 'clam' or 'junk') there may be open throws to unmarked people, but downfield progress may be more challenging; Forcing forehand makes backhands harder; Forcing 'straight up' makes it harder to throw long or to the centre of the field; etc.

Zone: Figure 1, left, shows a 3-3-1 zone forcing forehand[13], which might make throws amongst the handlers (O5, 6 and 7) easier as they are unmarked, but make throws to downfield players (O1-4) more challenging. Figure 1, right, shows this 3-3-1 zone having (potentially) 'trapped' the offence on the open-side sideline. But maybe O7 can get out of it[14]. This is just one of the many variants of 'zone' defence. Most of them aim to increase the number of passes needed to score and/or force more difficult throws to be made to make downfield progress. Typically, however, they tend to allow a 'free' pass

[1] And plenty of opinions. These are mine, but you can always fork the github repository (https://github.com/James-Reynolds/Ultimate-strategy-and-tactics), or send me a pull request if you have suggestions.

[2] They obviously simplify everything as much as possible. For example: the force is assumed to be forehand unless otherwise stated; O1-4 are the cutters, O5-7 are the handlers, D8-14 are on defence; Offence is always going down the page (the enemy's gate is down!). Some prior knowledge is assumed.

[3] ...then pulling to the other team to start the next point.

[4] a 'D', stall out, forced error, etc.

[5] 'throwaway', 'cold drop' etc.

[6] One throw to the endzone, with a 50% chance of completion...

[7] ...versus five throws to score, each with a completion rate of 90% (total 59%) or only 85% (total 44%).

[8] Plus second-order factors, where someone takes bigger risks because they think a turnover is likely to happen soon anyway.

[9] The possession/territory dilemma is common in many sports. But, unless it is really windy, ultimate seems weighted more towards possession.

[10] A 'clean hold'.

[11] A contested 'hold'.

[12] "Defence wins games. Offence loses them" *Old handler proverb (probably)*

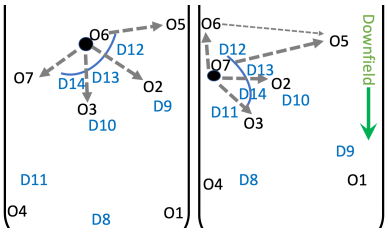



Figure 1: 3-3-1 zone

[13] 3-3-1: The first 3 are D12,13 and 14 (the 'cup', here possibly preventing throws *through* (to O2 and O3), but allowing throws to go *around* the cup (to O5 and O7), and probably unable to do much about throws *over* the cup). The second 3 limiting movement *around* (D9, D11: the wings) or *over* to the middle of the field (D10: the 'middle middle' or 'short deep'), while D8 (the 'deep deep') is covering downfield.

[14] (around) back to O6 to O5; (through or over) to O5 directly; (through) to O2 or O3; or (around) to O4.

back to one of handlers (O5-7) to retain possession and reset the stall count.

PERSON-MATCH DEFENCE is, as the name suggests, a defensive scheme where each O player is covered by a D player. Figure 2 shows this with the offensive team in a horizontal formation (left) or a vertical formation (right). There are many more. Generally each defensive player will seek to prevent their direct opponent from getting the disc. However, it isn't usually possible to cover everything[15], and this is something that offence can take advantage of by throwing a 'dump' pass.

To 'DUMP is to make a, typically short, throw[16]where the objective is to retain possession, reset the stall count to zero and/or improve position, rather than to make ground towards the endzone. Figure 3 shows two typical variations where O6 is dumping to O7 (Figure 3, left) or O5 (right). In both of these D14 and D12, respectively, likely cannot see everything at once and will likely have to choose between looking mostly at the thrower or mostly at the person they are marking. One approach to take advantage of this is the (so called) 'feldrunner' technique, where if the defender is looking at the thrower (O6) the receiver (O5 or O7) simply runs to one of A, B, C or D and O6 throws it to them. Alternatively, if the defender is looking at O5/7, O6 simply throws a soft pass to A, B, C or D that O5 or O7 can run onto. Importantly this tends to work better if the dump(s) (O5 and/or O7) are stationary until the thrower (O6) has 'engaged the dump' and is no longer looking to throw to a cutter downfield. And 'engaging the dump' tends to work better if you do it before the stall count gets too high[17], and might also depend on your role on the team[18]. As well, it might take a while to get a dump off[19].

Figure 4 shows a variation where the defender (D14) is giving a free pass to the dump (O7) so as to 'poach' and prevent downfield progress. If O7 is positioned back at 45 degrees, D14 is forced to choose whether to poach or match up. This poach can be exploited, as in Figure 4 (right) where O6 makes a 'give-go' throw then cuts 'down the line', taking advantage of the way that D13 is on the wrong side of them to prevent the pass back from O7. This simple pattern is difficult to stop, resets the stall count to zero, and puts O6 in 'power position'[20].

TAKEAWAYS are: (1) turnovers lose games; (2) there's a balance between maintaining possession and minimising throws taken to score; (3) against person-match a handler standing at 45 degrees (open side) or level (break side) may give the defence too much to cover.

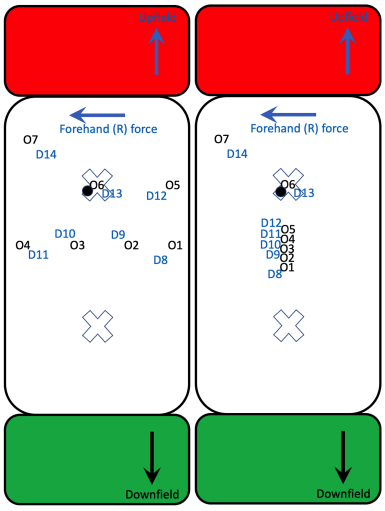



Figure 2: Person-match: open-side poach countered by 45 degree dump

[15] In Figure 2, left, D11 is covering O4 'deep' whereas D10 is covering O3 'under'

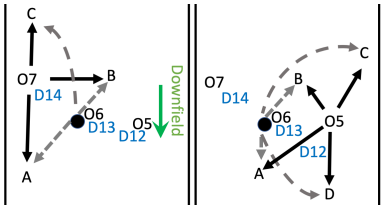



Figure 3: Person-match: tighter defence, open-side (left) or break-side (right) dumps.

[16] typically 'dumped' back to a handler

[17] 1-4 early but great, 5-6 getting a bit late, 7-8 not much time left now at all! 9 possession over, huck it downfield for territory instead

[18] If you are a cutter (O1-4), probably dump early and then head off to make another cut ASAP!

[19] If you 'engage' the dump on stall 4, you probably want to keep on looking to throw it to them until 8, to give them time to get open a couple of times (if they aren't already), then huck for position on 9

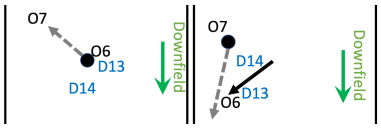



Figure 4: Person-match: open-side poach countered by 45 degree dump

[20] where, because they are probably now downfield of D13, when they catch the disc there is no force and they can throw almost anyway, opening the break side and/or making a huck (deep throw) easier.